been ruled by the Manchus.

It is important to remember that the Qing were, relatively speaking, an insular empire. The Ming prohibition on external trade and long-distance shipping continued under the Qing until these were dispensed with under a decree issued by the Qing emperor Kangxi in 1684. However, such trade was tightly controlled. Foreign trade was to be channelled only through the port of Guangzhou (Canton), with a certain number of Chinese merchants called ‘hong’ being licensed to interface with foreign merchants. This became known as the ‘Canton system’, and would be dismantled only in the wake of the two Opium Wars (1840–42 and 1856–60). During the initial years of the PRC, the Canton system was recreated through the annual Canton Trade Fairs, which became the sole platform for foreign traders, Chinese state agencies and state-owned enterprises to conduct business with foreign traders. While the Canton Trade Fairs still continue to be held, foreign trade is now conducted through both private and public sector enterprises, and in several cities of China, since the adoption of economic reforms and liberalization post 1978.

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Who were the Manchus? They were part of a group of tribes known as Jurchen, which occupied the area to the north-east of the heartland, beyond the Great Wall. They were a sedentary community, practising agriculture but retaining some of the pastoral culture of their steppe ancestors. The Manchus who gained control over China belonged to the Jianzhou Jurchen group, which traced its origins from the Jurchen Jin dynasty, which had much earlier ruled northern China (1115–1234 CE). The Jin were defeated by the Mongols and retreated into Manchuria during the reign of the Mongol Yuan dynasty. When the Ming overthrew the Mongol Yuan empire in 1368, the Jianzhou Jurchen became their tributaries, helping in the military operations against the Mongols. The border separating the Ming territory from that of the Jurchens became over time a permeable frontier, through which the Han garrisons stationed in the area mingled with the Jurchens and traded with them. When these garrisons were left unpaid